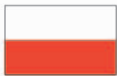


Poland



Located in the heart of Europe, Poland has undergone massive social, economic, and political change since the collapse of communism in 1989. It joined the EU in 2004.



GEOGRAPHY

Lowlands, part of the North European Plain, cover most of the country. The Tatra Mountains run along the southern border.



CLIMATE

Rainfall peaks during the hot summers. Cold winters with snow, especially in mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic homogeneity masks a number of tensions. Secular liberals criticize the semiofficial status of the Roman Catholic Church, and emerging wealth disparities are resented by those not profiting from the free market. The German minority in the west is growing more assertive.



INSIGHT: *Wild wisent (European bison) live in the Bialowieza Forest straddling the Poland–Belarus border*



THE ECONOMY

Foreign investment reflects the country's large potential market. Rapid privatization. Heavy industries dominate, though services growing. Plans to join euro in 2012.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Poland

DATE OF FORMATION: 1918

CAPITAL: Warsaw

POPULATION: 38.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 120,728 sq. miles
(312,685 sq. km)

DENSITY: 324 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Polish

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 93%, other and nonreligious 5%, Orthodox Christian 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Polish 97%, other 2%, Silesian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Zloty = 100 groszy